CONNEXUS | 2026
black sea tech forum

The Digital Hub as a Gateway to AI Factories



Innovation Amp

How InnovationAmp EDIH opens the door to the BRAIN++ AI Factory

Gerassim Y. Slavov · CONNEXUS 2026, Varna

ICT CLUSTER VARNA

BSMEPA
BULGARIAN SMALL AND MEDIUM ENTERPRISES PROMOTION AGENCY

ВАРНА

BRAIN++ AI FACTORY

ARC FUND

AI Factories are open. Are SMEs ready?

The last-mile problem

Europe's AI Factories put GPU compute, models and expertise within reach. BRAIN++ is Bulgaria's, selected by EuroHPC in March 2025.

Yet SMEs rarely start with a compute request. They start with a business problem, scattered data and no AI team.

Access calls and technical evaluations are a steep first step for a small—even mid-size—manufacturer or a municipality.

A Digital Innovation Hub bridges that gap: local, sector-aware and free of charge.

BRAIN++ AI FACTORY

InnovationAmp EDIH + BRAIN++ AI Factory

Two partners under one roof

InnovationAmp EDIH — the front door

European Digital Innovation Hub for big data, HPC and AI in Southwest Bulgaria

10-partner consortium incl. leading universities and a cluster of Sofia Tech Park entities

Digital maturity assessment, training, test-before-invest, access to finance

100% subsidised for SMEs, small mid-caps and public bodies

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DIGITECH powered by movebg and scion

DISCOVERER

GATE

ICT cluster DEVOTED TO DIGITAL TRANSFORMATI

NEVEQ new europe venture equity

SCAI THE POWER OF AI

Sofia Tech LABS

SOFIA TECHPARK

ТЕХНИЧЕСКИ УНИВЕРСИТЕТ СОФИЯ

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BRAIN++ AI Factory — the engine room

One of Europe's 13 AI Factories by EuroHPC

€90 million (half EU, half national), led by Sofia Tech Park

GPU compute for training, fine-tuning and inference on Discoverer infrastructure

Expert support across AI, data, HPC, robotics, business and compliance

Trustworthy-AI tools and data sovereignty

The gateway in practice

Five steps to GPU hours

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1 Diagnose	2 Skill up	3 Test before invest	4 Scale	5 Fund & grow
Digital maturity assessment shows where AI pays off and what data exists.	Targeted training for managers and engineers; an AI roadmap.	Prototype via the BRAIN++ Playground and the BulgAI Sandbox, with expert help.	Fast Lane or Large Scale access (6–9 months) on AI Factory GPUs.	Grant and investor support; Commercial route for start-ups and SMEs.
InnovationAmp	InnovationAmp	Joint	BRAIN++	Joint

Pills show who leads each step. EDIH services are free to the company. AI Factory access follows BRAIN++ eligibility review and technical evaluation.

BRAIN++ AI FACTORY

Matching each SME need to the right service

One door, two catalogues

The SME asks…	InnovationAmp EDIH	BRAIN++ AI Factory
Where do we start?	Digital maturity assessment, transformation roadmap	AI consultancy and expert support
Do we have the skills?	Courses, workshops, specialised software training	Training, bootcamps, co-working at Sofia Tech Park
Will it work?	Test before invest, prototyping, HPC via Discoverer	Sandbox access
How do we scale?	Help preparing a strong access application	GPU compute: Fast Lane and Large Scale routes
Is it compliant?	Cybersecurity training and simulations	COMPL-AI, GDPR and EU AI Act readiness, data governance
Who pays?	Grant applications, investor meetings	Commercial route for start-ups, SMEs and scale-ups

An invitation to the Black Sea region

The gateway is open beyond Sofia

Why it matters here

BRAIN++ serves Bulgaria, South-East Europe and the EU — not only the capital.

Its focus sectors match regional strengths: agri-food, healthcare, robotics, Earth observation, consumer goods and Bulgarian-language AI.

Maritime, logistics and tourism companies around Varna face the same last-mile problem — and deserve the same on-ramp.

How to start

Companies: start with a free assessment at InnovationAmp.

EDIHs and clusters: route AI-ready projects to BRAIN++ and co-design the application.

Ready to experiment: apply for Playground access at brainplusplus.bg.

The AI Factory is the engine. The Digital Hub is the on-ramp.



Thank you · innovationamp.eu · brainplusplus.bg · office@brainplusplus.bg